

CHORD INVERSIONS

The same chord tones reordered — inversions create smooth bass lines, voice leading efficiency, and new emotional shades.

An **inversion** places any chord tone other than the root in the lowest (bass) voice. The chord name doesn't change — only which note is on the bottom. Notated as **Chord/Bass** (e.g., C/E means C chord with E in the bass).

TRIAD INVERSIONS — C MAJOR (C-E-G)

POSITION	BASS NOTE	STABILITY	NOTATION	CHARACTER
Root Position	Root (C)	Most stable	C	Grounded foundation. Strong arrival point. Use for beginnings, endings, and strong beats.
1st Inversion	3rd (E)	Lighter	C/E	Smooth, elegant, slightly softer. Excellent for harmonizing scale degree 3 in the melody (creates seamless motion in the bass).
2nd Inversion	5th (G)	Least stable	C/G	Creates a P4 above the bass — contextually unstable. Used in specific contexts: cadential 6/4 (IV 2nd inv before V) or passing movement.

7TH CHORD INVERSIONS — G7 (G-B-D-F)

POSITION	BASS NOTE	STABILITY	NOTATION	CHARACTER
Root Position	Root (G)	Most stable	G7	Full, strong dominant. Direct and powerful resolution drive.
1st Inversion	3rd (B)	Lighter	G7/B	Smooths the bass line when harmonizing scale degree 7. Classic pop use: harmonizes B in the melody moving up to C (e.g., "Man in the Mirror").
2nd Inversion	5th (D)	Less stable	G7/D	Less common. The D in the bass weakens dominant drive slightly. Used for passing motion or pedal tone contexts.
3rd Inversion	♭7th (F)	Most active	G7/F	The F (♭7) in the bass creates a harsh m2 against the expected resolution. Creates maximum forward pull. Used in Bach chorales and dramatic jazz passages.

THREE FUNCTIONAL INVERSIONS YOU'LL ACTUALLY USE

1

I/3RD
C/E

Softens the harmonization of scale degree 3 in the melody. Creates a smooth descending bass line: C → C/E → F. Commonly used in pop ballads for a gentler Tonic chord.

2

V/7TH
G/B

"Man in the Mirror" — MJ bridge
Smooth harmonization of scale degree 7 ascending to 8 (B → C). The B in the bass rises stepwise to C — the most elegant possible bass resolution. Pop and gospel staple.

3

III/5TH
Em/B

"Shape of My Heart" — Sting
Most melancholic harmonization of scale degree 5. Em/B creates a descending bass line feel (G → Em/B → C/E). The B in the bass sustains before resolving. Deeply introspective character.